

Asia Chart Alert

Global Markets Research

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Economics - Asia Pacific/Asia ex-Japan

Asia's widening current account divide

The AI boom is widening the current account divergence between North and Southeast Asia, with the war-driven oil shock amplifying this divide.

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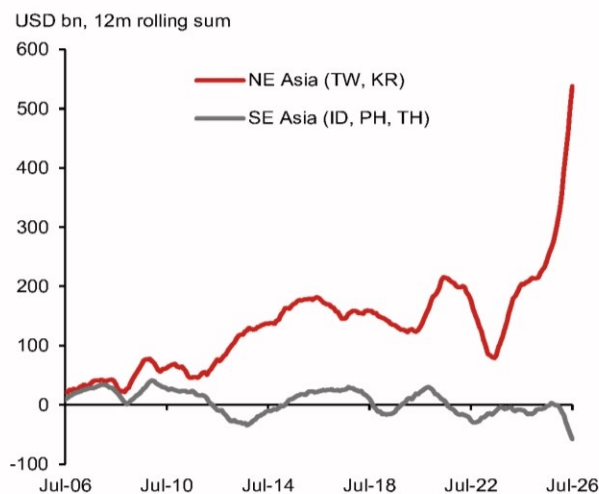
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Fig. 1: Current account balance, USD bn (12m rolling sum)



- The current account divergence between North and Southeast Asia is becoming increasingly stark. Northeast Asia's surplus has surged to a record high of USD538bn (12-month sum to July 2026), while deficits across parts of Southeast Asia have widened.
- This divide is a manifestation of the AI boom's uneven impact. Taiwan and Korea dominate higher-value upstream segments of the tech supply chain, which enable them to capture significant export upside from surging demand for AI servers and memory chips, whereas parts of Southeast Asia are more concentrated in lower-value assembly and downstream manufacturing, which benefit less from the AI boom. Moreover, data centre investment is proving more import-intensive, leading to *persistent electronics trade deficits* in Thailand.
- The oil shock is amplifying this divide. Higher oil prices are a negative terms-of-trade shock for Southeast Asia, most visibly in Thailand, the Philippines and *Indonesia*, which do not have the *surging chip export price* offsets of Northeast Asia.
- We expect this current account divide to persist and translate into stronger external buffers in Northeast Asia, leaving Southeast Asia more exposed to external financing conditions and vulnerable to currency depreciation, particularly if El Niño worsens and oil prices remain elevated.

Note: We use monthly current account data for countries that report them, namely South Korea, the Philippines and Thailand. For countries that do not report monthly current account data (i.e. Taiwan and Indonesia), we evenly distribute the quarterly data across the months in each quarter. Current account data for the month of July have not been released for Taiwan, Indonesia and the Philippines, so we use June data for these countries. Country abbreviations used in the chart are as follows: TW=Taiwan; KR=Korea; ID=Indonesia; PH=Philippines; TH=Thailand.

Source: CEIC and Nomura Global Economics.

Appendix A-1

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